



NURSE AI OS • SETUP GUIDE 1 OF 2

Hermes Essentials

The budget-smart setup for nursing students and cost-conscious staff nurses: run your own AI assistant for nearly nothing, on a system with a conscience built in.

Agents propose. Humans judge. Nurses steward.

Free for nurses and nursing students • Founding Year 2026 • nurse-ai-os.org

Who this guide is for

You count your dollars, your hours, or both. You want a working personal AI assistant — study maps, shift prep, life admin — without a subscription that quietly eats a textbook's worth of money every semester. This guide gets you there in one evening, and shows you the safety architecture working for you the whole time.

The one rule before anything — no patient data. Ever. No names, charts, screenshots, room numbers, or stories that could identify a patient. This system runs on *your* life — never your patients.

Run it nearly free — the money moves first

Hermes itself is free and open-source. The only cost is the AI model that powers it — the pump is free; what runs through it is metered. Here is the lowest-cost route:

1 Choose Bring Your Own Keys

In Hermes setup, pick **Full Setup** (not the default subscription option), then **Bring Your Own Keys**. This connects Hermes to a model account you control.

2 Create an OpenRouter account

One free account at openrouter.ai, one API key from the dashboard, and a whole menu of models — including free and very low-cost ones.

\$ Set the spending limit BEFORE pasting the key

In OpenRouter, cap your spend at a few dollars. This is your safety rail against surprise bills — you can always raise it, and it means the worst-case month costs less than one coffee run.

3 Paste the key, pick a free model, test

Choose OpenRouter as the provider in Hermes, paste your key, and start with a free model. Ask something simple. If answers feel weak, step up one tier — trying models costs nothing but the tokens you use.

Triage the task, then pick the model

You would not call the code team for a splinter. Match the model to the acuity:

Task acuity	Examples	Model tier
Low	Quick questions, summaries, rewrites, brainstorming	Free or cheapest
High	Study plans, long documents, multi-step projects	Stronger reasoning model
Visual	Screenshots, diagrams, error messages	Vision-capable model

One caution: a ChatGPT Plus or similar chat subscription usually does *not* include API access — that is billed separately. The safest wallet is a dedicated OpenRouter key with a limit you set yourself.

The lean install — five steps, one evening

1 Run the Pre-Procedure Checklist, then install

The time-out before the procedure: right equipment (desktop or laptop), field prepped (one dedicated folder, nothing private inside), fresh Gmail for your AI life. Full checklist: nurse-ai-os.org/cheat-sheet.html. Then install from the official site: hermes-agent.nousresearch.com.

2 Take the SOUL Quiz, hand over your SOUL file

Ten browser-only minutes at nurse-ai-os.org produce **Core-SOUL.md** — your values, boundaries, and priorities as standing instructions. Drag it into Hermes and ask it to confirm what it understood.

3 Give it the Starter Kit

The free ZIP builds your **My-Nurse-AI-OS** folder — the only folder Hermes gets access to. A room, not the house.

4 Build your dashboard with one prompt

The starter kit includes a Local HTML Life Dashboard; one prompt personalizes it from your quiz answers. Bookmark the result — that is your station board.

5 Run your first huddle

Say: "Run my morning huddle." It asks your number-one priority and offers three ways to help. That is the whole daily habit.

EDENA — the conscience already in your architecture

You did not just install an app. You installed a stack — and one of its layers thinks about safety so you do not have to hold it all in your head. **EDENA (Ethical Design & Enablement for Nursing Augmentation)** is the governance framework embedded in the background architecture of Nurse AI OS. It classifies every action your AI takes, before it runs:

● **GREEN** — low risk, may proceed

● **YELLOW** — conditional, you approve first

● **RED** — human authorization mandatory, always

You — judgment, values, the final word on everything that matters

Your SOUL file — your values and boundaries as standing instructions

EDENA — the conscience layer: classifies, gates, and keeps a human hand on every risky action

Starter Kit structure — one governed folder; memory, projects, and notes in their place

Hermes engine — the free, open-source horsepower underneath it all

You don't install EDENA — you inherit it. The SOUL file and Starter Kit are how its values reach your engine: the harness on a powerful horse. Everyday translation for the budget setup: drafting your study plan is Green; anything touching money, other people, or public posting is Yellow — you approve first; and anything clinical or patient-related is Red — it never belongs in this system at all.

Keep the music playing

Cheap models for drafts, strong models for final passes, spending limits on, and no huge files unless the task truly needs them. Watch usage the way you watch supplies. And you are never alone in this: the free AI course and 55 free mentors run in any browser, and the monthly Lamp Huddle is where questions go. **nurse-ai-os.org**

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